

vomiting, contact your doctor or midwife immediately. If you have a sudden onset of a severe headache, you should also consult your doctor. Make sure you drink enough clear fluids and avoid caffeine. If you're working or concentrating on a task, have regular breaks, and get some fresh air. From 12 weeks, it's safe to take two 500mg acetaminophen tablets every eight hours, with no more than three doses in a 24-hour period. If you suspect your headache is due to lack of sleep, try to get more sleep. And make sure you're eating enough, since hunger and low blood sugar can cause headaches. Relieve stress—another headache trigger—with deep breathing, meditation, yoga, or massage. Always discuss your symptoms with your doctor before taking medication.

Swollen feet, ankles, hands, and wrists can be particularly pronounced in hot weather. **Causes** Swelling is the result of fluid retention, which in turn results from the extra blood produced during pregnancy.

What to do Alternate light activity with periods of rest during which your feet are elevated. However, avoid staying in bed or sitting in a chair for very long periods as this may increase the risk of deep vein thrombosis (DVT). Swollen feet and ankles can also be a sign of other problems such as [preeclampsia](#) so should always be reported to your doctor who can check for other symptoms.

Skin changes

Itching and dry skin may worsen in the second and third trimester. Such skin irritation is a reaction to hormonal changes and can be eased by a perfume-free moisturizer. Rarely, itching in late pregnancy may be due to [obstetric cholestasis](#). This itching is much more severe, usually constant, and concentrated on the palms of the hands and soles of the feet. If you develop itching, tell your doctor or midwife who will arrange a blood test.

Increased pigmentation is due to the increased production of hormones. Most women notice a darkening of the area around the nipple and a dark line, the linea nigra, vertically through the middle of the bump from the umbilicus to the pelvis. Also common are dark patches on the cheeks, nose, and chin, known as melasma (or the “mask of pregnancy.”) On women with dark skin, the patches may appear lighter than surrounding skin. Use a high-protection sunscreen cream on your face.

Stretch marks Rapid stretching of the skin during pregnancy often leads to the development of pink or purple lines. These stretch marks usually appear in late pregnancy, commonly on the abdomen, hips, thighs, and upper breast. There is no clear evidence that any cream will prevent or remove stretch marks, although a light unscented moisturizer can help keep the skin supple, as will staying well hydrated and avoiding excessive weight gain. As time passes after the birth, stretch marks become silvery and almost invisible.

Breast problems

Breast tenderness is often one of the first signs of pregnancy, sometimes becoming so painful that you can't bear them to be touched; they may also throb and feel hot. This usually subsides by the end of the first trimester.

Causes The milk ducts are starting to enlarge and blood flow increases.

What to do Wear a properly fitted bra to support your breasts and reduce discomfort. An ill-fitting or tight bra will be uncomfortable and may put pressure on the milk ducts. You may also find it helpful to wear a soft sleep bra or bralette at night. If your breasts feel hot, applying a cool cloth to them may bring relief. If you have a painful or red patch on a breast, tell your doctor as it could be [mastitis](#).